50TH ANNIVERSARY

AGITATIONS 2015-2025



SEEDS OF DISSENT JNU students protest Kanhaiya Kumar's arrest, Feb. 18, 2016

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Dalit Power
Apr. 16, 2018

❝ As the heat of the day built up on April 2, regular commuters were checking if anyone had heard of a Bharat Bandh called by little-known Dalit groups. They were apparently protesting a Supreme Court ruling that had diluted the stringent provisions of the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989. By noon, though, most of India knew about the Bharat Bandh as TV screens began flashing images of street violence in 10 states, with groups of seemingly leaderless Dalits clashing with police or upper-caste gangs. ❞





Patriot Wars
Mar. 7, 2016

❝ Revelations this week have suggested that Kanhaiya did not participate in chanting slogans about breaking up and dividing India; that the 'Pakistan zindabad' slogan was wrongly attributed to him by a news channel; lawyers have claimed that the Delhi Police supported them while they were manhandling Kanhaiya in court, and that they had been given a tacit go-ahead by the police. ❞

layer to the social disquiet. The Jats in Haryana sought inclusion in the OBC category, while the Marathas in Maharashtra demanded recognition as Kunbis—both aiming to access reservations in education and employment. The Jat agitation turned violent in 2016, bringing Haryana to a halt. Maratha discontent, meanwhile, continues to smoulder under the leadership of the slight Manoj Jarange-Patil who has gone on hunger strikes in pursuit of his demand.

Back in Delhi, a gender storm blew up in January 2023 as women wrestlers demanded investigation into allegations of sexual misconduct against former BJP MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh during his presidency of the Wrestling Federation of India.

But the most formidable challenge to state authority came from the hardy farmers of Punjab. Rallying under the cry 'Dilli Chalo', they blockaded the capital's entry points, braving the COVID winter of 2020 to protest the Modi government's farm laws, which they feared would leave them at the mercy of market forces. Faced with the farmers' unrelenting anger, the Centre capitulated, repealing its laws. ■